

**Blu-ray players compared**

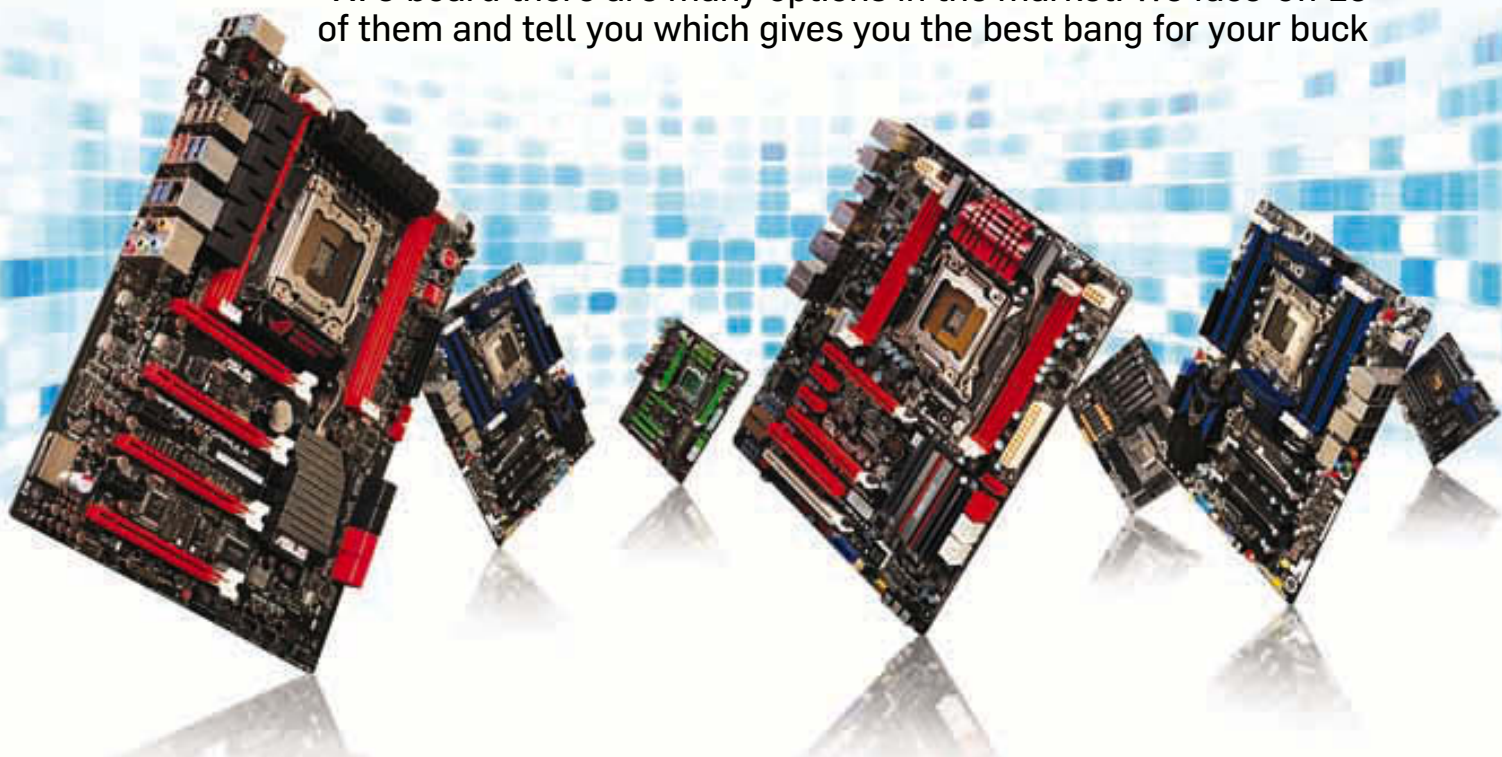
We compare Blu-ray players from Philips, Panasonic, Sony and LG to find out which is the best Blu-ray player on the market

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# Shine X79

For those wanting to build an ultra high-end rig with the Intel X79 board there are many options in the market. We face-off 16 of them and tell you which gives you the best bang for your buck



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## Features

The Big Bang Xpower II is the flagship board from MSI which has as many as 7 PCIe slots of which four are PCIe 3.0 compatible and you can lodge up to four GPUs at a time. It comes in the XL-ATX form factor. In an effort to stand out from the crowd, MSI has used a machine-gun sort of design for the VRM heatsink, with the Southbridge made of bullet magazine. There are enough SATA 6 Gbps ports for you to set up many RAID configurations. There are dedicated voltage check points and a PCIe switch for quick troubleshooting of faulty graphics cards or switching cards off to

save power in a multiple GPU setup. Using the + and - buttons on the board, you can tweak the clock or voltage settings easily while overclocking the board.

The other two MSI boards that we got were the X79A-GD45 (8D) and X79A-GD65 (8D). Both these boards are very similar except for some incremental improvements in the GD65 such as better heatsink over the VRM section, more SATA ports and more USB ports.

Gigabyte sent us the X79-UD3 and X79-UD5. Both the boards have a black PCB, with the UD5 sporting some familiar blue on its heatsinks. The X79-UD3 makes up for the absence of four DIMM slots by having four PCIe x16 slots which allow a 4-way SLI / CrossFireX as

opposed to only 3-way SLI / CrossfireX on the UD5. The UD5 offers an extra add-in card for Bluetooth 4.0 and WiFi on board. The card can be lodged into the PCI x1 slot and has a WiFi and Bluetooth antenna outs. A USB port is present on the inner side of the card which seems strange. There is an OC button on the back panel IO below which there is BIOS switch button to toggle between the backed up BIOS in case of system crash.

The Z68 ASRock boards had us impressed with their wonderful feature set and snazzy heatsink design. The X79 Extreme 9 and X79 Extreme 6/GB take a leaf out of that book with angular designs on the heatsinks over the VRM, at least

9 SATA ports on both boards, an actively cooled southbridge and provision for 3-way SLI/CrossfireX. It offers a Game Blaster hybrid card which has four auxiliary ports along with an optical and coaxial out and a LAN port. Creative SoundCore 3D offers the sound whereas Broadcom BCM57781 chip offers LAN connectivity. The fan on the Southbridge spins only when the chipset is under load which is good. Layout of both the boards is quite good. We were pleased to see the board offering two USB 3.0 headers. If we were to nit-pick with the Extreme 9 board, it's that the last PCIe slot, blocks access to power/reset button.

It bundles in an overclocking utility called AXTU which lets you tweak fan controls, DRAM